

Link Building That Still Works

Five tactics with real conversion rates, four that carry real penalties, and an honest price per link.

Bottom line

The tactics that work in 2026 all share one property: a real person on the other end has an actual reason to link. Unlinked mention reclamation converts best at **30 to 50%**, digital PR is rated most effective overall, and the average earned link costs about **\$750**. The tactics that get you hurt are the ones that scale, which is not a coincidence.

What works, with numbers

Tactic	Reported performance	Effort
Unlinked mention reclamation	30 to 50%+ conversion, highest of any tactic	Low
Digital PR and original research	Rated most effective by 34% to 48.6% of practitioners surveyed	High
Journalist outreach (Connectively, Qwoted, Featured.com)	1 to 2 quality links/month at 2-3 responses per day	Medium, sustained
Broken link building	5 to 15% conversion	Medium
Linkable assets (tools, calculators, datasets)	Earn passively, indefinitely	High upfront, near-zero ongoing

[practitioner]

Two survey figures disagree on digital PR's effectiveness rating (34% versus 48.6%) because they polled different populations. Both rank it first. The disagreement is about magnitude, not direction, which is the useful way to read conflicting practitioner data.

Start with reclamation, always

If you did the Section 32 lab you already have this list.

Someone has already written about you without linking. They mentioned your brand, quoted you, referenced your research, or listed you among alternatives. The editorial decision, the expensive part, is already made. You are asking for a hyperlink, not for coverage.

That is why it converts at 30 to 50% when cold outreach converts in low single digits.

How to find them:

- Search "your brand name" -site:yourdomain.com and scan for pages that mention you without linking
- Set up a Google Alert on your brand name and your founder's name
- Ahrefs Content Explorer or Semrush Brand Monitoring will do this systematically if you have either

How to ask: short, specific, no template. Name the sentence where you are mentioned, say thanks, ask if they would mind linking it. Three sentences. The conversion rate collapses when this reads like a campaign.

Do this before anything else in this section. It is the cheapest authority you will ever acquire.

Digital PR and original research

The highest-rated tactic and the most expensive one, which is a fair trade.

The mechanism: you produce something a journalist genuinely wants, usually data that did not previously exist. A survey of your customers, an analysis of a dataset you have access to, or a benchmark study of your industry. Then you pitch it to writers covering that beat.

Why original research specifically: it is citable. A journalist writing about your industry needs a number, and if you are the only source of that number you get linked by everyone who covers it, indefinitely, without further outreach. This is the closest thing to a compounding asset in link building.

What makes a pitch work:

- **A genuine news angle.** Not "we launched a feature." A finding that surprises someone.
- **The data available immediately.** Journalists work on deadlines measured in hours.
- **A specific writer, not a press list.** Read what they actually cover.
- **A subject line that is the finding,** not your company name.

What it costs: the average earned digital PR link runs about **\$750** in agency terms once you account for research production, pitching time, and hit rate. Budget accordingly and be honest with clients about it. [practitioner]

Journalist request platforms

Connectively (formerly HARO), **Qwoted**, and **Featured.com** publish live journalist requests for expert quotes.

Realistic expectation: 1 to 2 quality links per month at 2 to 3 responses per day. That is a genuine time commitment for a modest, reliable return. [practitioner]

The response rate rewards speed and specificity. Answer within the first hour of a request, give a quotable two to three sentence answer rather than an offer to talk, and include your credential in one line. Most responses journalists receive are generic and late.

This is the tactic best suited to a founder who is genuinely expert and has 20 minutes a day. It is poorly suited to delegation, because the value is in the expertise being real.

Broken link building

Conversion: 5 to 15%. Modest but honest work. [practitioner]

Find a page in your niche that has died, find the sites still linking to it, and offer your equivalent resource as a replacement. The pitch is genuinely useful to the recipient, which is why it converts at all, and the conversion ceiling is set by the fact that many site owners simply do not maintain their pages anymore.

Best used opportunistically rather than as a primary channel.

Linkable assets

A free tool, a calculator, a template, an ongoing dataset. Something people link to because they need to reference it, not because you asked.

High upfront cost, near-zero ongoing cost, and the links accrue for years. The failure mode is building an asset nobody needs. Validate demand before building: if nobody currently searches for the thing your tool does, nobody will link to it either.

What gets you hurt

Tactic	Outcome
Private blog networks (PBNs)	Pattern detection catches shared hosting and content footprints within weeks . Outcome is domain-level suppression or deindexing
Link exchanges	Graph clustering identifies reciprocal networks. Reported 15 to 40% ranking drops
Mass guest posting	98% of sites on guest-post marketplaces are low quality (DR under 40 and under 10k monthly traffic)
Bulk directory submissions	Zero value, plus NAP inconsistency risk that actively harms local rankings (Section 35)

[practitioner]

That 98% figure is the one to remember when someone offers you a guest post package. You are not buying links from good sites at a discount. You are buying links from the sites that nobody with

standards will accept.

Reciprocal linking at small scale is not a penalty. Linking to a partner who links back is normal web behavior. The detected pattern is systematic, at volume, between sites with no other relationship. Do not panic about three mutual links with genuine partners.

The honest position on paid links

Paid links violate Google's guidelines. They also demonstrably work in some niches in the short term, which is why the market exists, and pretending otherwise damages your credibility with anyone who has been in the industry.

The case against is not moral, it is risk arithmetic: the sites selling links are selling to everyone, which builds exactly the footprint graph analysis detects, and the downside is domain-level, not page-level. You are risking the entire site's rankings on an asset you do not control. For a business that depends on organic traffic, that is a poor trade regardless of short-term results.

If a client insists, document the recommendation against it in writing.

Do this now

- 1 Take the unlinked mentions list from Section 32.** If it is empty, run the brand search again including your founder's name and any product names.
- 2 Send three reclamation emails today.** Three sentences each, naming the specific sentence where you are mentioned. No template.
- 3 Sign up for Connectively or Featured.com** and set alerts for your topic areas.
- 4 Answer one journalist request properly:** within the hour, two to three quotable sentences, one line of credential.
- 5 Draft one original research angle.** What data do you have access to that nobody has published? A survey of 100 customers is enough to be citable.
- 6 Identify one linkable asset** you could build. Check whether people currently search for it before committing.
- 7 Audit your existing profile for the four risky patterns.** Any PBN-looking domains, reciprocal rings, marketplace guest posts, or bulk directories.
- 8 Track outcomes:** emails sent, replies, links earned. Link building without a tracked conversion rate is a hobby.

Capstone step

Your capstone site has one full outreach cycle completed: reclamation emails sent to every existing unlinked mention, an account on a journalist request platform with at least one answered request, one original research angle drafted, and a tracked record of outreach sent versus links earned.

Key takeaways

- Reclaim unlinked mentions first. **30 to 50% conversion** because the editorial decision is already made, and it costs almost nothing.
- Digital PR with original research rates most effective and costs about **\$750** per earned link. Original data compounds because it stays citable.
- Journalist platforms return **1 to 2 links a month** for 2 to 3 responses a day. Real work, reliable return, poorly suited to delegation.
- The tactics that get you hurt are the ones that scale. **98% of guest-post marketplace sites are low quality**, and PBN footprints are caught within weeks at domain level.